FORSCHUNGSWERKSTATT

RAUMKONZEPT / AUSSTELLUNGSARCHITEKTUR, FRANKFURT, 2022



Forschungswerkstatt (2022) Frankfurt

In 2022, YRD.Works realised the architecture of the Aha?! Research Workshop at the Senckenberg Nature Museum in Frankfurt — a permanent museum infrastructure for education, workshops and collection work, housed in the museum's former staff break room in the basement. The museum had approached the collective in 2021 to carry an existing educational concept forward architecturally and to think of the room as an independent artistic position.

The task was to create an interface between scientists and the public — to make research spatially visible and to allow visitors to question experts directly. At the same time, the room needed a high degree of flexibility to switch between focused work, open workshop formats and events. The existing building set tight conditions: low ceilings, concrete columns, little daylight. These conditions were not concealed but made the starting point of the design.

The central element is a large mobile collection shelf made of five sliding units — a spatial translation of Senckenberg's scientific collections, which normally remain closed to the public. Moving the shelves creates different spatial situations without the room losing its inner order. Along the long sides are brightly lit, laboratory-like work niches in which microscopes, books and original collection objects stand side by side as equals. An integrated French cleat system of two bevelled battens — one fixed to the wall, the other on changing fittings such as magnetic boards or showcases — makes the wall surfaces reconfigurable at any time.

Between the collection shelves and the work niches runs a deep blue, dark walkway that gives the room calm despite the low ceiling. The contrast between the neutral, almost laboratory-like work zones and the dark blue shell creates an atmosphere that feels both technically focused and sheltering. A seating grandstand opens the room up as a situation of observation: from there, parents can watch their children working at microscopes or searching through research boxes with original specimens — a setting that puts visitors in a dual role, as actors and observers at the same time.

Since then, the Research Workshop has worked without constant explanation. Collection shelf, work niches, grandstand and blue walkway together form an infrastructure that can be switched between research, education and lingering — thereby transferring the museum's otherwise hidden backbone, collection and laboratory, into a publicly accessible space.

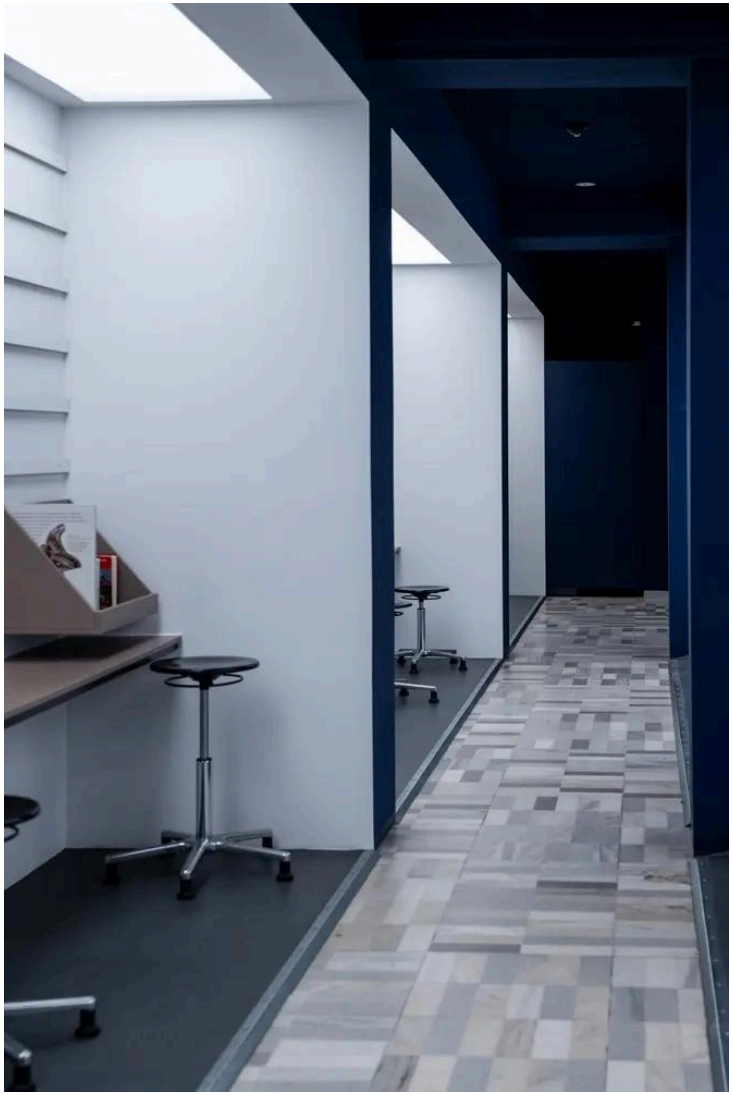




Forschungswerkstatt (2022) Frankfurt



Forschungswerkstatt (2022) Frankfurt



Forschungswerkstatt (2022) Frankfurt